

Word family: **paper / papers / papered / papering / papery / paperwork / newspaper**

Base word: paper

Plural: papers

Related forms: papery

Useful family extensions: paperwork, newspaper, paperless

Useful expressions / extensions: a piece of paper, paper bag, paper money, research paper, exam paper, newspaper, on paper, put something on paper, paper over

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective-like modifier (名詞作修飾語) / verb (動詞)

Your sentence:

> “He can spend hours playing with Lego, drawing imaginary cities, or folding **paper rockets** out of old notebooks.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **paper** refers to the familiar thin material used for writing, drawing, printing, or folding.

In **paper rockets**, it functions as a noun modifier:

> **paper rockets = rockets/models made of paper**

繁體中文： **紙**；用來書寫、繪畫、印刷或摺疊的薄片材料

中文翻譯：

> “He can spend hours ... folding paper rockets out of old notebooks.”

「他可以花幾個小時.....用舊筆記本的紙摺**紙火箭**。」

Here:

paper = 製作火箭模型所用的紙張材料

1. **paper = material for writing/printing/folding (紙) — 紙；紙張**

This is the exact sense in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “He can spend hours ... folding **paper rockets** out of old notebooks.”

「他可以花幾個小時.....用舊筆記本的紙摺**紙火箭**。」

Practice 2

> “She wrote the address on a piece of **paper**.”

「她把地址寫在一張**紙**上。」

Practice 3

> “The children used coloured **paper** to make decorations.”

「孩子們用彩色**紙張**製作裝飾。」

paper = 由纖維製成的薄片材料，常用於書寫、印刷、繪畫、包裝或手工製作

2. **a piece/sheet of paper** (紙張單位) — 一張**紙**

Because **paper** as material is usually uncountable.

Practice 4

> “Can I have a sheet of **paper**?”

「可以給我一**張紙**嗎？」

Practice 5

> “He folded a piece of **paper** into a plane.”

「他把一**張紙**摺成飛機。」

a piece/sheet of paper = 一張 / 一片紙，用來把不可數的 paper 量化

Important:

> **a paper** does not normally mean simply 「一張紙」.

3. **paper + noun** = made of paper (紙製的) — 紙的；紙製

This is your exact grammatical pattern.

Practice 6

> “Leo made a **paper rocket**.”

「Leo 做了一個**紙火箭**。」

Practice 7

> “She carried a **paper bag**.”

「她拿著一個**紙袋**。」

****paper + noun = 表示後面的物件主要由紙製成****

Common:

- * paper bag
- * paper cup
- * paper plane
- * paper towel
- * paper box

4. ****paper = newspaper (報紙) — 報紙****

A major countable meaning.

Practice 8

> “I read it in the **paper** this morning.”

「我今早在**報紙**上看到這件事。」

Practice 9

> “Which **paper** do you normally read?”

「你平時看哪一份**報紙**？」

****paper = newspaper ; 一份報紙或報章****

Here ****paper**** is countable:

> a paper

> several papers

5. **the papers = newspapers collectively (報章) — 各大報章 ; 新聞報紙**

Practice 10

> “The story was all over the **papers**.”

「各大**報章**都報道了這件事。」

Practice 11

> “The **papers** criticized the decision.”

「多份**報紙**批評了這個決定。」

the papers = 多份報章 / 報紙作為新聞媒體的集合稱呼

6. **paper = academic article/research paper (論文) — 學術論文 ; 研究文章**

A major separate meaning.

Practice 12

> “She published a **paper** on language learning.”

「她發表了一篇關於語言學習的**學術論文**。」

Practice 13

> “I read several research **papers** before writing the report.”

「寫報告前，我閱讀了幾篇研究**論文**。」

paper = 正式討論研究、理論或學術問題的文章，尤其指學術期刊或會議論文

7. **paper = student essay/assignment (文章 / 報告) — 報告 ; 論文**

Especially common in American academic English.

Practice 14

> “I have to write a ten-page ****paper****.”

「我要寫一篇十頁的****報告 / 論文****。」

Practice 15

> “Her history ****paper**** is due on Friday.”

「她的歷史科****論文 / 作業****星期五要交。」

****paper** = 學生為課程撰寫的較正式文章、報告或論文

8. ****paper** = exam/test paper (試卷) — 試卷 ; 考卷

A major educational meaning, especially British/Commonwealth English.

Practice 16

> “Turn over your exam ****paper****.”

「把你的考試****試卷****翻過來。」

Practice 17

> “The mathematics ****paper**** was difficult.”

「數學****試卷****很難。」

****paper** = 考試中包含題目的試卷 ; 亦可指某一科 / 某部分考試

9. ****paper** = examination subject/session (考試科目 / 卷別) — 一份考卷 ; 考試部分

Practice 18

> “I have two ****papers**** tomorrow.”

「我明天有兩****科 / 兩份考試****。」

Practice 19

> “The listening ****paper**** lasts forty minutes.”

「聆聽**考卷 / 考試部分**為時四十分鐘。」

paper = 某次考試中的一個科目、卷別或部分

This use is common in British/Commonwealth educational contexts.

10. **papers = documents (文件) — 文件 ; 證件**

A major plural lexicalized use.

Practice 20

> “Please bring your identity **papers**.”

「請帶同你的身份**證明文件**。」

Practice 21

> “He signed the **papers** before leaving.”

「他離開前簽署了那些**文件**。」

papers = 正式文件、證明文件、法律文件或需要簽署的文書

Often plural.

11. **paper = official/documentary record (文書 / 文件形式) — 文件 ; 書面資料**

Practice 22

> “We need to get everything down on **paper**.”

「我們需要把所有事情**寫成書面文件**。」

Practice 23

> “There is no agreement on **paper** yet.”

「目前還沒有任何**書面協議**。」

paper = 以書面文件形式記錄下來的內容

Here the material sense has developed into:

> written documentation.

12. **on paper = in written/theoretical form (在紙面上 / 理論上) — 表面上 ; 理論上**

A very common figurative expression.

Practice 24

> “The plan looks good **on paper**.”

「這個計劃**理論上 / 紙面上**看起來很好。」

Practice 25

> “**On paper**, the team should be very strong.”

「**單看條件 / 理論上**，這支隊伍應該很強。」

on paper = 按照書面資料或理論條件來看，但實際情況可能不同

This is a genuine figurative extension.

13. **put something on paper (寫下來) — 寫成文字 ; 記錄下來**

Practice 26

> “Try to **put your ideas on paper**.”

「試著把你的想法**寫下來**。」

Practice 27

> “The agreement was finally **put on paper**.”

「協議最後終於**以書面形式記錄下來**。」

put something on paper = 把想法、安排或協議轉成書面形式

14. **paper = money in banknotes (紙幣) — 紙幣**

Usually in compounds or specific contexts.

Practice 28

> “Many countries are using less **paper money**.”

「很多國家正在減少使用**紙幣**。」

Practice 29

> “He paid with **paper currency**.”

「他用**紙幣**付款。」

****paper money/currency = 以紙張 / 類似材料製成的實體貨幣鈔票****

15. **paper = wallpaper (壁紙) — 牆紙**

A traditional countable/uncountable use, especially through the verb.

Practice 30

> “They chose a patterned **paper** for the bedroom walls.”

「他們為睡房牆壁選了一款有圖案的**牆紙**。」

Practice 31

> “The old **paper** was peeling off the wall.”

「舊**牆紙**正在從牆上剝落。」

****paper = wallpaper ; 用來覆蓋和裝飾牆面的紙質材料****

This bare-noun use is less common than simply saying **wallpaper** today.

16. **paper — verb = cover a wall with wallpaper (貼牆紙) — 貼牆紙**

Practice 32

> “They ****papered**** the bedroom walls.”

「他們替睡房牆壁****貼了牆紙****。」

Practice 33

> “The room was ****papered**** in a floral design.”

「房間貼上了花卉圖案的****牆紙****。」

****paper a wall/room = 在牆面貼上牆紙****

17. ****paper over = conceal a problem superficially (掩蓋問題) — 掩飾 ; 粉飾****

A very useful figurative phrasal extension.

Practice 34

> “They tried to ****paper over**** their disagreements.”

「他們試圖****掩蓋彼此的分歧****。」

Practice 35

> “The new policy only ****papers over**** the deeper problem.”

「新政策只是****暫時掩飾更深層的問題****。」

****paper over something = 表面上掩蓋問題，而沒有真正解決其根本原因****

The metaphor is like covering a crack with wallpaper.

18. ****paper trail (書面紀錄) — 文件紀錄 ; 可追查紀錄****

A useful established compound.

Practice 36

> “The transactions left a clear ****paper trail****.”

「這些交易留下了清楚的****文件紀錄 / 追查線索****。」

Practice 37

> “Investigators followed the **paper trail**.”

「調查人員循著**文件紀錄**追查。」

paper trail = 由文件、收據、紀錄等形成，可用來追查某項活動的證據鏈

Today this can include digital records too, despite the word **paper**.

19. **paperwork** = administrative documents/tasks (文書工作) — 文書；行政文件工作

A major family extension.

Practice 38

> “I spent all morning doing **paperwork**.”

「我整個早上都在處理**文書工作**。」

Practice 39

> “There is a lot of **paperwork** involved.”

「這件事涉及很多**文件 / 行政手續**。」

paperwork = 填寫、整理、提交或處理正式文件的行政工作

Usually uncountable.

20. **newspaper** = newspaper publication (報紙) — 報章；報紙

Practice 40

> “My grandfather reads the **newspaper** every morning.”

「我外公每天早上都看**報紙**。」

Practice 41

> “The story appeared in several **newspapers**.”

「這宗新聞刊登在幾份**報章**上。」

newspaper = 定期出版、刊載新聞和其他資訊的報刊

This makes explicit the lexical extension behind **paper = newspaper**.

21. **paperless = using digital rather than paper documents (無紙化的) — 無紙化的**

Practice 42

> “The office is moving toward a **paperless** system.”

「辦公室正在轉向**無紙化系統**。」

Practice 43

> “Many banks now offer **paperless** statements.”

「很多銀行現在提供**無紙化電子結單**。」

paperless = 不依賴實體紙張，而主要使用電子 / 數碼文件的

22. **papery = resembling paper (像紙的) — 薄如紙的；紙質感的**

Practice 44

> “The flower has thin, **papery** petals.”

「這種花有薄薄、**像紙一樣的花瓣**。」

Practice 45

> “The leaves become dry and **papery**.”

「葉子變得乾燥而**薄脆如紙**。」

papery = 在薄、乾、脆、質感等方面像紙的

23. **paper tiger (紙老虎) — 外強中乾的人 / 組織**

A common figurative compound.

Practice 46

> “The organization looked powerful but turned out to be a **paper tiger**.”

「那個組織看似強大，其實只是**紙老虎 / 外強中乾**。」

Practice 47

> “Critics described the threat as a **paper tiger**.”

「批評者把那個威脅形容為**紙老虎**。」

paper tiger = 表面看起來強大或可怕，但實際力量很弱的人、組織或威脅

24. **paper thin** (薄如紙；極薄) — 薄如紙的；非常薄的

Practice 48

> “The slices were **paper-thin**.”

「那些薄片切得**薄如紙張**。」

Practice 49

> “There was only a **paper-thin** wall between the rooms.”

「兩個房間之間只有一道**非常薄的牆**。」

paper-thin = 像紙一樣極薄的

Can be literal or metaphorical.

25. **paper-thin** = very weak/slight (非常薄弱的) — 極微弱的；薄弱的

A figurative extension.

Practice 50

> “They won by a **paper-thin** margin.”

「他們只以**極微小的差距**勝出。」

Practice 51

> “His excuse was **paper-thin**.”

「他的藉口**非常牽強 / 站不住腳**。」

paper-thin = 程度、差距、解釋等薄弱到幾乎不能成立

Important distinction: **paper = material vs a paper = article**

This is essential.

paper — material

usually uncountable:

> “I need some paper.”

= 我需要一些紙。

a paper — academic article

countable:

> “I read a paper.”

= 我讀了一篇論文。

So:

> **three papers**

normally means three documents/articles/exams/newspapers depending on context—not simply three sheets of blank paper.

For blank sheets:

> **three sheets/pieces of paper**

Important distinction: **paper vs page**

paper

= the material.

page

= one side/sheet section of a book, notebook, document, etc.

> “The paper is white.”

= 紙是白色的。

> “Turn the page.”

= 翻頁。

A notebook contains pages made of paper.

Important distinction: **paper vs card/cardboard**

paper

= relatively thin flexible material.

card/cardboard

= thicker and more rigid.

Your passage has:

> **paper rockets**

but later:

> **a cardboard bridge**

The material difference is meaningful.

Important distinction: **paper vs document**

paper

can mean a physical sheet/material or certain formal written works.

document

means:

> a written/digital item containing recorded information.

A document may exist entirely digitally and contain no paper at all.

Important distinction: **paper vs article**

In academia:

paper

often means:

> a formal research article or scholarly work.

article

is broader:

- * journal article
- * newspaper article
- * magazine article
- * online article

Not every article is a research paper.

Important distinction: **paper vs essay**

essay

focuses on an organized piece of writing presenting ideas/arguments.

paper

in academic contexts can be broader and may include:

- * research
- * analysis
- * data
- * literature review

In American education, the terms often overlap.

Important distinction: **paper = newspaper vs newspaper**

paper

is the shorter informal/common form:

> “I saw it in the paper.”

newspaper

is explicit and unambiguous.

> “I bought a newspaper.”

Both can refer to the same publication.

Important distinction: **exam paper vs answer sheet**

exam paper

= contains questions/tasks.

answer sheet

= where answers are recorded.

Sometimes the same physical booklet serves both purposes, but the concepts differ.

Important distinction: **on paper vs in reality**

This is a very important figurative contrast.

on paper

= according to plans, written facts, statistics, or theory.

in reality / in practice

= what actually happens.

> “The idea works on paper, but not in practice.”

= 這個想法理論上可行，但實際上不行。

Important distinction: **paper money vs money**

money

is the general concept.

paper money

specifically means physical banknotes.

Digital balances, coins, and other assets are money but not paper money.

Important distinction: **paperwork vs paper**

paper

= material/document/article etc.

paperwork

= administrative work involving documents.

You cannot normally count paperwork:

> **a lot of paperwork** 

> **many paperworks** 

Important distinction: **paperless vs no paper**

paperless

specifically describes:

> a system/process that has deliberately moved from physical paper to digital handling.

It does not merely mean that there happens to be no paper present.

Important distinction: **paper over vs solve**

paper over a problem

= hide/smooth over its appearance temporarily.

solve a problem

= actually deal with its cause.

So:

> papering over a problem

strongly implies the problem remains underneath.

Important distinction: **paper rocket — material modifier vs paper = academic article**

In your sentence:

> **paper rocket**

means:

> rocket/model made from paper.

Compare:

> **research paper**

Here **paper** means:

> scholarly article.

Same spelling, completely different lexical role.

Family-extension note

Paper is a strong moderate polysemy word because it moves well beyond the physical material.

Its major learner-relevant semantic centres include:

- * **paper material**
- * **paper-made object modifier**
- * **newspaper**
- * **academic paper**
- * **student paper**
- * **exam paper**
- * **official papers/documents**
- * **written documentary form**
- * **wallpaper / paper as a verb**

The useful fixed and family extensions include:

- * **on paper**
- * **put something on paper**
- * **paper over**
- * **paper trail**
- * **paperwork**
- * **newspaper**
- * **paperless**
- * **papery**
- * **paper tiger**
- * **paper-thin**

The curation should keep the genuine lexical shifts—especially **material** → **publication/document/article/exam**—while not splitting every compound made from the physical material into a new bare-word sense. That matches the manual’s broad word-family sweep and conservative semantic splitting.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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paper — material	用於書寫、印刷、繪畫、包裝或手工製作的薄片材料

piece/sheet of paper	一張 / 一片紙；用來量化不可數的 paper	
paper + noun — material modifier	表示後面的物件主要由紙製成	
paper — newspaper	一份報紙 / 報章	
the papers	多份報章作為新聞媒體的集合稱呼	
paper — academic article	正式呈現研究、理論或學術分析的論文 / 文章	
paper — student assignment	學生為課程撰寫的較正式文章 / 報告	
paper — exam	考試中的試卷、卷別或科目	
papers — official documents	正式、法律、身份或需要簽署的文件	
paper — written record	以書面文件形式存在的內容 / 紀錄	
on paper	按書面資料或理論條件來看，而非實際情況	
put something on paper	把想法、安排或協議寫成書面形式	
paper money	實體紙幣 / 鈔票	
paper — wallpaper	用來覆蓋裝飾牆面的牆紙	
paper — verb	在牆面貼上牆紙	
paper over	表面掩蓋問題而沒有真正處理根本原因	
paper trail	由文件 / 紀錄形成、可供追查的證據鏈	
paperwork	填寫、整理、提交或處理正式文件的行政工作	
newspaper	定期出版並刊載新聞資訊的報紙	
paperless	主要使用數碼文件而不依賴實體紙張的	
papery	在薄、乾、脆或質感方面像紙的	
paper tiger	表面強大但實際力量薄弱的人 / 組織 / 威脅	
paper-thin — literal	像紙一樣極薄的	
paper-thin — figurative	差距、理由、支持等非常薄弱或微小的	

For your original sentence

> “He can spend hours playing with Lego, drawing imaginary cities, or folding ****paper rockets**** out of old notebooks.”

The exact meaning is:

****paper = 用來摺疊和製作物件的實體紙張材料****

Therefore:

> ****paper rockets****

= ****「用紙摺 / 製作出來的火箭模型」****

And:

> ****out of old notebooks****

tells us that Leo is reusing the notebook pages as material.

So this is the straightforward ****physical-material sense****, functioning as a modifier:

> **paper + rocket**

It is not:

* **a research paper** = 研究論文

* **an exam paper** = 試卷

* **the paper** = 報紙

* **official papers** = 正式文件

* **on paper** = 理論上 / 紙面上

In the passage, **paper** simply identifies **what the rockets are made from**.